Human-made Things in the Bible © United Bible Societies, 2025. Adapted from: The Works of Their Hands: Man-made Things in the Bible, by Ray Pritz © 2009 United Bible Societies. This work is licensed under Creative Commons Attribution-ShareAlike 4.0 International (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-sa/4.0/).

Writing tablet, tablet of brass/bronze

1.7.6 Writing tablet, tablet of brass/bronze

References:

Hebrew גִּלָּיוֹן (gilayon) ISA 8:1

Hebrew לוּחַ (luach) EXO 24:12, EXO 31:18, EXO 31:18, EXO 32:15, EXO 32:15, EXO 32:16, EXO 32:16, EXO 32:19, EXO 34:1, EXO 34:1, EXO 34:1, EXO 34:4, EXO 34:4, EXO 34:28, EXO 34:29, DEU 4:13, DEU 5:22, DEU 9:9, DEU 9:9, DEU 9:10, DEU 9:11, DEU 9:11, DEU 9:15, DEU 9:17, DEU 10:1, DEU 10:2, DEU 10:2, DEU 10:3, DEU 10:3, DEU 10:4, DEU 10:5, 1KI 8:9, 2CH 5:10, PRO 3:3, PRO 7:3, ISA 30:8, JER 17:1, HAB 2:2

Greek δέλτος (deltos) 1MA 8:22, 1MA 14:18, 1MA 14:26, 1MA 14:48

Greek πινακίδιον (pinakidion) LUK 1:63

Latin buxus 2ES 14:24

Description:

Wax writing tablet (Metropolitan Museum of Art, CC0, MMA)The writing tablet was a small, flat board, normally made of wood. It was coated on one side with a thin layer of wax. A pointed stick or stylus was used to make marks and letters in the wax layer for short messages. After use, the wax could be smoothed out and used again. Several tablets could be connected along one edge by cord in order to make a kind of book. See the illustration at 1.7.5 Stylus<REALIA:1.7.5>. It is possible that

the Old Testament references are to tablets made of clay, metal or stone, on which words were scratched directly with a hard, pointed object.

The tablets mentioned in 1 Maccabees were flat pieces of polished brass or bronze on which words were inscribed. The sizes of these tablets are unknown, but they would probably not have been very large.

Translation:

Translators should avoid a word that indicates a modern "tablet" of writing paper.

PRO 3:3; PRO 7:3; JER 17:1: The Hebrew word *luach* has a figurative meaning in these passages and may be rendered without reference to an actual writing tablet; for example, GNT renders PRO 7:3 b as "write it on your heart," and ITCL has "guard them in your heart like a treasure."

Although one or two of the references with the Greek word *deltos* speak of the tablets as containing "letters" (that is, correspondence), such tablets were not the normal medium for letters. According to 1MA 8:22, they were special memorial documents, intended "as a memorial of peace and alliance" (RSV). Some cultures may have special documents that are exchanged between people groups when they make treaties or alliances.